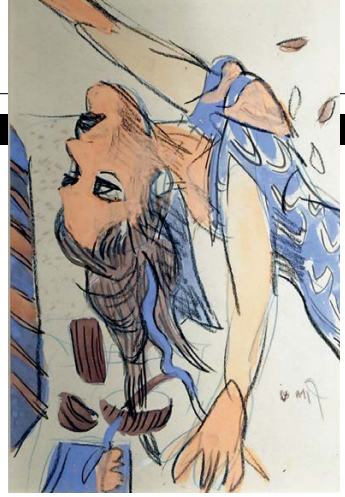






WORKS OF WISDOM 'Uma' (extreme left) and other untitled works by K.G. Subramanyan that are part of the exhibition

EXHIBITION

The Traditional Modernist

Artist **K.G. Subramanyan***'s centenary is being celebrated with a major exhibition at Arthshila, Santiniketan*

K. G. Subramanyan (1924-2016), who had in his decades-long career as an innovative teacher, writer, designer and artist been associated with Kala Bhavana, Visva-Bharati University, which was his alma mater, and MS University, Baroda, once said of his art: "You could call it the apotheosis of the ordinary." The current exhibition, *Mani Da: A Centenary Exhibition of KG Subramanyan*, on at Arthshila, Santiniketan, till March 27, demonstrates the deep understanding he had of his own practice. Having keenly observed and absorbed the life around him, "Mani da", as he was fondly called by students and acquaintances, allowed the alchemy of his imagination to transform mundane experiences into a rich tapestry of life where global cultures melded unhindered by geographical boundaries, and where time flowed either way effortlessly, or froze at his bidding.

Sculptor K.S. Radhakrishnan, himself an alumnus of Kala Bhavana, who conceptualised the exhibition, says the 150 works on display were sourced from the art collection of the Takshila Education Society, which has 300 of the artist's works in its possession. Beginning with the 1950s and ending with works done when Subramanyan was already in his 90s, the 150 paintings are displayed in three halls of the gallery.

Ever ready to experiment, Subramanyan was a painter, printmaker, toy maker, muralist and relief-sculptor who made significant contributions to institutions like the All India Handloom Board and the World Craft Council Board. However, here he is represented by his spontaneous drawings with brush, pencil and wax, paintings with water colours and gouache on paper and acrylic sheets and enamel painting on iron sheets. Gestures and facial expressions were intrinsic to Subramanyan's work, and here is a series of drawings where his protagonists, both male and female, are engaged in dramatic exchanges involving their eloquent hands and equally expressive facial muscles and eyes. A canny observer, Subramanyan is not above poking fun at their theatrics and interpersonal relationships, sexual and otherwise. His sly digs at the householders of Oxford painted around 1987 are in the same satirical mode. His russet portrait of Uma, his daughter, stands out, a picture of quiet dignity.

He often likened his art to that of the *bahurupee*—the quick-change artiste or "volatile polymorph", to quote him—and Subramanyan's painting moves into the "fairytale" realm as multi-armed goddesses accompanied by their mounts invade the picture space. These divinities could have been inspired by Durga or deities drawn from other exotic and non-Puranic folk cultures. Screeching felines and barnyard animals trail them, occasionally triggering a state of turmoil. The divine and the quotidian intermingle. Swift brush strokes give vivid form to simian, canine, avian and caprine residents of Santiniketan. When he played around with grids and human forms, the distinction between the abstract and the representational disappeared. Subramanyan has said: "I want my work to be ambiguous.... Also I want to straddle the visible and the abstract with their forms now becoming recognisable, now going into hiding."

Mani Da: A Centenary Exhibition of KG Subramanyan is on at Arthshila, Santiniketan, till March 27

This subtlety, Subramanyan asserted, was in keeping with the Indian tradition. Modernist though he was, he was unwilling to forsake tradition. ■

–Soumitra Das